# ChatGPT Quick Start Guide.

Small steps for higher education: organize your work, pick the right settings and let ChatGPT handle the repeats.

**YOUR FIRST WEEK**

**Day 1** Create a project with instructions and one file

**Day 2** Find the model and effort controls

**Day 3** Set one scheduled task and check its result

Full checklist on page 3.

START HERE

## 01 Put each ongoing job in a Project

A Project is a folder for chats, files and instructions about one job. Every new chat in it starts with that context, so you stop re-explaining.

| Stop repeating yourself | Keep files in reach | Keep work separate |
|---|---|---|
| Write project instructions once, such as audience, tone and format. Every chat in the project follows them. | Upload the syllabus, policy or template once. ChatGPT draws on it in every project chat. | Project-only memory keeps a project's chats apart from your other conversations. Shared projects always use it. |

**01** Pick one recurring job, such as a course, committee or weekly report.

**02** Create a project and name it after that job.

**03** Add two or three reference files and a few lines of instructions.

**04** Move related chats into the project. They pick up its instructions and files.

- Share a project with Edit or Chat access when a colleague needs the same context. Use approved, de-identified files and follow your student-data policy.

PICK A MODEL AND EFFORT

## 02 Match the model to the work. Start at low effort.

| LOW | LOW OR MEDIUM | HIGHER, PLUS REVIEW |
|---|---|---|
| **Narrow and repeated** | **Judgment across sources** | **Consequential decisions** |
| Try GPT-6 Luna at Low for sorting, extraction or a task with a clear right answer. | Use GPT-6.1 Sol at Low or Medium for reports, reconciling documents and multistep work. Use the lowest effort that passes your check. | Increase effort when needed and add human review. Keep scope explicit. Consult your campus policy and the current Model Value Map. |

**Open the AI Model Value Map**

Raise effort only after a result fails your check. Higher effort takes more time and usage. Menu labels and models vary by account and campus settings.

CHAT, WORK OR CODEX?

## 03 Choose the surface for the result

| Chat | Work | Codex |
|---|---|---|
| Questions, quick drafts and explanations. | Multistep jobs that produce a finished artifact. | Code, tests and repositories. |

**QUICK WIN** Connect an approved document service, find five recent documents and ask for a one-line summary of each.

SCHEDULED TASKS

## 04 Let ChatGPT show up on a schedule

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **MON** Open items and deadlines. | **WED** Find stale documents in an approved shared folder. | **FRI** Draft a weekly update for review. |

**01**
Open Scheduled when available, or describe the task and when it should run.

**02**
Choose a one-time or recurring schedule. Supported connected apps may offer event triggers.

**03**
Review the account, sources, instructions and permissions before relying on a run.

**04**
Check results and paused tasks in Scheduled. Codex automations are managed separately.

- Computer-bound tasks need that device available. Cloud tasks have different requirements. If a task's model retires, update it before the next run.

FIND USEFUL TOOLS

## 05 Start with the work you already do

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| GOOGLE DRIVE, GMAIL, OUTLOOK<br>**Documents and email**<br>Find an approved document, summarize a thread or draft a reply. | CONSENSUS, QUIZLET<br>**Research and study**<br>Explore research or build practice flashcards, where available. Check sources and accuracy. | CANVA<br>**Design**<br>Turn an outline into an event flyer, where available. Review the result before sharing. |

- Also check Calendar, SharePoint, Slack, Teams and Notion. Availability varies. Use approved campus services and de-identified examples; follow your student-data policy.

MAKE, BUILD OR BORROW

## 06 Turn a task you repeat into a skill

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Make a skill**<br>You repeat a focused task, such as a weekly update or a document review. | **Make a plugin**<br>A workflow needs connected services or a bundle your team can reuse. | **Install one**<br>Search the Plugins directory before building a tool that already exists. |

**01**
Name one repeated task and its required result.

**02**
Use Skill Creator where available. Describe the goal, steps and output format.

**03**
Test with de-identified examples and refine the instructions.

**04**
Share where your workspace permits. Name a maintainer and provide example prompts.

- Good first skills: meeting notes to action items, policy-template checks or clearer help articles.

HABITS FROM A WORKING SETUP

## 07 Six habits that make AI more useful

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **1** Name the task, the tools and the result you want. | **2** Ask ChatGPT to challenge your request if it is unclear. | **3** Keep a short handoff in each project: done, next and open questions. |
| **4** Verify facts and saves before you rely on them. | **5** Search for an existing tool before you build one. | **6** Add one new habit at a time. |

KNOW THE DIFFERENCE

## 08 A skill handles a task. A plugin bundles a workflow.

| | Custom GPT | Skill | Plugin |
|---|---|---|---|
| PURPOSE | A separate chatbot | Reusable task instructions | Skills, files and connected capabilities |
| TOOLS | Apps or custom actions | Uses tools available to the task | May include connected apps |
| SHARING | Existing GPT permissions | Account and workspace controls | Share intentionally; apps authorize separately |

INSTALL AND SHARE

## 09 Test privately. Share on purpose.

**01**
Open Plugins or the app directory shown in your account. Review the tool and its capabilities.

**02**
Select Install plugin when shown, then connect required apps using the intended account.

**03**
Start a chat and mention the installed tool where supported.

**04**
For your own plugin, test first, add example prompts and name a maintainer. Workspace publication is a separate permission.

- Installing a plugin does not grant access to files or bypass your provider's permissions. Recipients may need to install it and connect their own apps.

IF YOU BUILT CUSTOM GPTS

## 10 Move your GPTs to plugins before they retire

| RETIREMENT Dec 11 2026 | What moves | What needs attention | Your move |
|---|---|---|---|
| | Published GPT instructions become a skill. Reference files and supported connected apps can move with the plugin. | Custom actions and sharing settings need review or rebuilding. Existing conversations remain accessible. | When available, open My GPTs > Migrate to plugin. Test familiar requests in the same workspace before switching. |

- Follow your account or campus notice. For affected Enterprise workspaces, October 26 is the planned end of new GPT creation.

## Try these next.

ONE A DAY. TICK AS YOU GO.

- [ ] Create a project with instructions and one file
- [ ] Set one scheduled task and check its result
- [ ] Create one focused skill with Skill Creator
- [ ] Ask your campus admin what tools and data are allowed
- [ ] Find the model and effort controls
- [ ] Connect one approved app and summarize a document
- [ ] Run one multistep task in Work
- [ ] If you own custom GPTs, plan and test their replacement

SOURCES AND CURRENT GUIDANCE

Projects in ChatGPT
Plugins and connected apps
Model specifications and API prices
AI Model Value Map
Skills in ChatGPT
October Chat model release
GPT retirement and migration
Scheduled tasks
Current model guidance